

WORK VAN SAFETY STUDY GUIDE

Module: Fatigue Management

The Critical Danger of Drowsy Driving

Purpose: To equip drivers with the knowledge and skills to identify, prevent, and manage fatigue to ensure safety on the road.

KEY WARNING (NTSB/AAA) vs CRASH STATISTICS

KEY WARNING (NTSB/AAA)	CRASH STATISTICS
Driving while fatigued can be just as dangerous as driving drunk.	At least 400,000 police-reported crashes each year involve drowsy driving.
It Doesn't Take a Week: One night of not getting enough sleep is enough to potentially impair your driving performance.	This results in approximately 115,000 injuries and at least 5,000 fatalities annually.
The Rule: Drivers often want to 'get home' when tired, but the safe choice is always: 'I should have pulled over.'	41% of Americans admit to falling asleep or nodding off at the wheel.

1. Recognizing the Signs of Fatigue

A critical part of safety is knowing what fatigue looks and feels like. If you experience any of these symptoms, you must take immediate action.

Physical Signs (The Body)	Mental Signs (The Mind)	Emotional Signs (The Mood)
Heavy Yawning or rubbing eyes	Daydreaming or mind wandering	Irritability or impatience
Heavy eyelids or blurred vision	Difficulty remembering the last few miles driven	Feeling moody or detached
Head bobbing or micro-sleeps	Missing traffic signs or turns	Taking risks you normally wouldn't
Restless movements and muscle stiffness	Trouble keeping a constant speed or lane position	Indifference to company safety rules

2. Proactive Prevention Strategies

- **Prioritize Sleep:** Aim for a minimum of 7-9 hours of quality, uninterrupted sleep per 24-hour period.
- **Plan Breaks:** Incorporate a stop for at least 15 minutes every two hours of driving into your route plan.
- **Check Meds:** Be aware of any prescription or over-the-counter medications that list drowsiness as a side effect.
- **Eat Smart:** Avoid heavy, high-fat meals (especially at lunch) that can lead to digestive sleepiness and the natural afternoon slump.

- **Stay Hydrated:** Drink plenty of water and limit your overall reliance on caffeine for long-term alertness.

3. Immediate Action: When Symptoms Appear

When you recognize fatigue, stop immediately. Do not try to "push through" it using short-term fixes—these are temporary and dangerous.

INEFFECTIVE Strategies (AVOID)	EFFECTIVE Strategies (IMPLEMENT)
Turning up the radio or singing loudly.	PULL OVER SAFELY: Find an authorized, safe rest area immediately.
Rolling down the window for cold air.	TAKE A POWER NAP: 15 to 30 minutes is ideal for a quick recharge. Set an alarm.
Relying on caffeine or energy drinks alone.	GET ACTIVE: Get out of the van, walk briskly, and stretch for a few minutes.
Driving faster to get to the destination sooner.	NOTIFY SUPERVISOR: Inform your manager that you are taking a necessary safety break.

4. Special Risk Factors for Work Van Drivers

- **Increased Effort:** Managing cargo, vehicle length, braking distance, and higher center of gravity demands more alertness. Fatigue reduces your ability to handle these factors.
- **Deadlines:** Pressure to meet deadlines can tempt drivers to skip breaks. **NO DEADLINE IS WORTH THE RISK OF A CRASH.**
- **Monotony:** Long, consistent drives can cause highway hypnosis. Vary your visual focus and stop regularly.

5. Company Safety Policy & Accountability

DRIVER'S RESPONSIBILITY	MANAGEMENT'S COMMITMENT
You have the absolute right and duty to refuse to drive if you are too fatigued to do so safely.	Schedules and workloads will be managed to ensure they do not encourage or require fatigued driving.
You must perform a self-assessment of your fitness to drive before and throughout your shift.	You will be supported in taking necessary rest breaks when fatigue is reported.
Follow all protocols for reporting incidents and near-misses related to fatigue.	Safety comes before all else.

This guide is based on safety principles reinforced by NTSB, AAA, and other traffic safety experts.